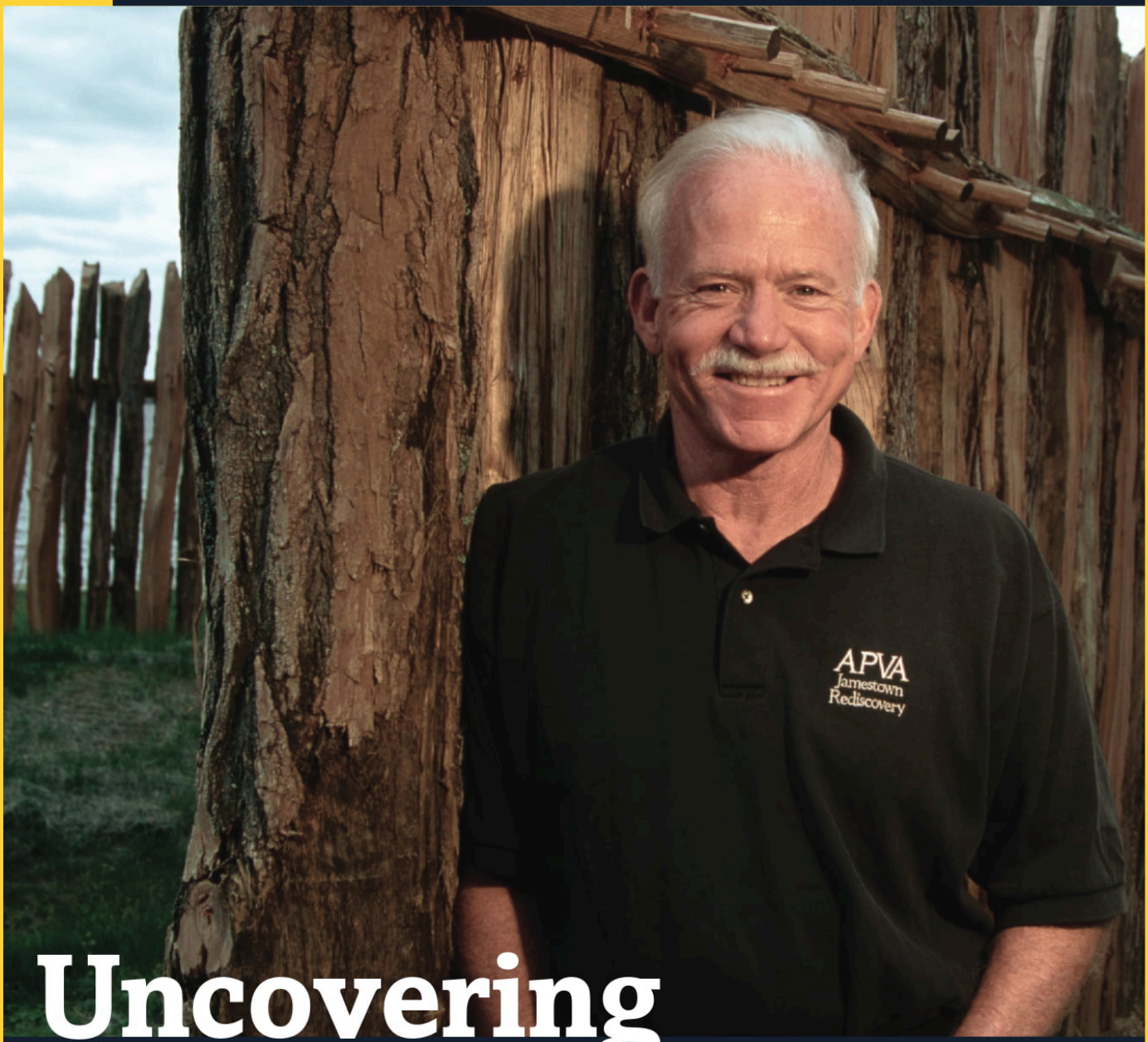
1.3 NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC EXPLORER WILLIAM KELSO



Uncovering Where America Began

"The American dream was born on the banks of the James River." —William Kelso

The experts said the Jamestown fort had washed away without a trace, but **William Kelso** didn't believe them. He saw something in a glassed-in cross-section of dirt exhibited at the Jamestown ranger station that suggested something might still lie below the surface. So, in 1994, Kelso set out alone with his shovel and hit pay dirt almost immediately: earth stained dark by logs that had decayed long ago. Thus began his quest for Jamestown's buried truths.

^ Kelso stands next to a portion of the Jamestown fort that he and his team reconstructed. The archaeologist has worked for more than 20 years in Jamestown in part because, as he says, "This is America's site. It belongs to the people."

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MAIN IDEA Archaeologist William Kelso has uncovered evidence at Jamestown that is changing how people view the settlement.

EARLY DISCOVERIES

National Geographic Explorer William Kelso's search began in 1994. In anticipation of the 400th anniversary of Jamestown's founding, the Association for the Preservation of Virginia Antiquities had announced plans to investigate the island. Kelso volunteered for the job.



This map shows the triangular Jamestown fort and the houses that stood within it. Chief Powhatan sits at the top right of the map, while ships full of settlers arrive on the island along the James River.

About all he had to go on were some historical accounts and documents, including a roughly drawn Spanish map from 1608 showing the triangular Jamestown fort. But he also knew that the only aboveground ruins that had survived in Jamestown were parts of a church tower. Kelso reasoned that the settlers would have built the fort near the church, so he began there. Fragments of early 1600s ceramics and the dark-stained dirt told him that he was on the right track.

THE TRUTH ABOUT JAMESTOWN

In time, Kelso identified evidence of all but one corner of the fort's structure as well as thousands of artifacts. He and his team—at this point, Kelso wasn't working alone anymore—began reconstructing the fort, using the materials and tools available to the Jamestown settlers. During this process, he discovered just how tough the settlers had been. Kelso says, "They were cutting down trees, digging holes, building forts, building buildings, digging ditches." The skeletons that Kelso has excavated also reveal how hard the settlers' lives were. Many died during the starving time of the early years and in the wars with Native Americans. Others couldn't adapt to the new environment. Lifespans were short.

One misconception about Jamestown is that it was a failure, but the settlers got many things right. Historians have often faulted them for establishing their colony in what was basically a marsh. But they needed to find a place where they could defend themselves against the Spanish. Locating their settlement on an island worked—the Spanish never attacked. Above all, they developed a new form of government. Around 1619, the settlers organized a representative assembly that met at the church. According to Kelso, "That's when liberty got out of the bag, and nobody could stuff it back in."

These findings have told us a lot about the site, and Kelso hopes to uncover more. But now the sea level around Jamestown Island is rising. Soon, important evidence may disappear. And Kelso believes the site is worth preserving. For, as he says, "This is where America began. This is where the English settlers first became American."

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What did Kelso learn about the Jamestown settlers from his excavations?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the settlers choose Jamestown as the site for their colony?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What action on the settlers' part was key to the development of American constitutional democracy?

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